

RAQP — CEFR Alignment Document

Roots Arabic Qur'an Proficiency Exam (/pathways-exam) mapped to the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR).

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What this document is

The **RAQP** (Roots Arabic Qur'an Proficiency exam) is a general proficiency exam in Modern Standard Arabic and Qur'anic Arabic vocabulary. Every question is tagged to a **CEFR level** (A1, A2, B1, or B2) at the time it enters the item bank. This document is the public record of how that mapping is made, so any school, employer, or evaluator can verify that a Roots CEFR level claim is honest.

The RAQP does **not** award C1 or C2 at present. C1/C2 claims require an oral/production component that a fully-multiple-choice exam cannot rigorously assess. A future oral extension of the RAQP will make C1/C2 possible; this document will be updated when that ships.

Structure of the exam bank

The current RAQP bank contains **240 items** across four CEFR levels and four school-type variants:

CEFR Level	Roots Name (Arabic)	Warm-up items	Exam items	Total per level
A1	مُبْتَدِئ (Mubtadi — Beginner)	20	40	60
A2	أَسَاسِي (Asasi — Foundation)	20	40	60
B1	مُتَوَسِّط (Mutawassit — Intermediate)	20	40	60
B2	مُتَقَدِّم (Mutaqaddim — Advanced)	20	40	60
Total		80	160	240

Every level is further stratified into four school-type variants — **Primary (ages 5–11)**, **Middle (ages 11–14)**, **High School (ages 14–18)**, and **Adult (18+)** — so the same CEFR level asks age-appropriate questions of a 7-year-old, a 12-year-old, a 16-year-old, and a 30-year-old. The CEFR claim (A1 through B2) is the *language proficiency* claim; the school-type variant only changes the presentation, not the level of difficulty.

Exam items also carry a **topic tag**: vocabulary, grammar, reading, or Qur'an. Warm-up items are untagged.

CEFR "can-do" descriptors and RAQP mapping

CEFR level descriptors are the property of the Council of Europe (see *Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: Learning, teaching, assessment*, Companion Volume, 2020). Below is the standard descriptor for each level, alongside the specific RAQP evidence used to confirm placement.

A1 — Beginner (Mubtadi | مُبتدئ)

STANDARD CEFR DESCRIPTOR

"Can understand and use familiar everyday expressions and very basic phrases aimed at the satisfaction of needs of a concrete type. Can introduce him/herself and others and can ask and answer questions about personal details such as where he/she lives, people he/she knows and things he/she has. Can interact in a simple way provided the other person talks slowly and clearly and is prepared to help."

RAQP EVIDENCE

- Recognizes and pronounces the 28 letters of the Arabic alphabet in isolated and connected forms
- Reads short vowels (fatha, kasra, damma), sukoon, and shaddah in isolated words
- Recognizes ~150 high-frequency vocabulary items (family, home, food, common actions)
- Identifies simple sentence structure (subject + predicate; nominative case)
- Matches basic Qur'anic words to their meanings (بيت, يوم, نور, ماء)

EXAMPLE ITEM TYPE

ما معنى كلمة (بيت)؟

- أ) مدرسة
- ب) بيت
- ج) سيارة
- د) كتاب

A2 — Foundation (Asasi | أساسي)

STANDARD CEFR DESCRIPTOR

"Can understand sentences and frequently used expressions related to areas of most immediate relevance (e.g. very basic personal and family information, shopping, local geography, employment). Can communicate in simple and routine tasks requiring a simple and direct exchange of information on familiar and routine matters."

RAQP EVIDENCE

- Reads short paragraphs on familiar topics and answers comprehension questions
- Recognizes ~400 vocabulary items including basic verb forms (past, present)
- Identifies gender (masc/fem) and number (singular/dual/plural)
- Understands definite article (ال) — Shamsiyah/Qamariyah
- Recognizes basic Tajweed rules of Madd, Ghunnah, and simple stopping (waqf)
- Reads simple Qur'anic phrases and identifies meaning at the phrase level

EXAMPLE ITEM TYPE

Read the following: "الطَّالِبُ يَذْهَبُ إِلَى الْمَدْرَسَةِ". What is the student doing?

- a) sleeping
- b) going to school
- c) eating
- d) reading

B1 — Intermediate (Mutawassit | مُتَوَسِّط)

STANDARD CEFR DESCRIPTOR

"Can understand the main points of clear standard input on familiar matters regularly encountered in work, school, leisure, etc. Can produce simple connected text on topics which are familiar or of personal interest. Can describe experiences and events, dreams, hopes and ambitions and briefly give reasons and explanations for opinions and plans."

RAQP EVIDENCE

- Reads and comprehends multi-paragraph texts including narrative and expository styles
- Recognizes ~1,200 vocabulary items across a wider semantic range
- Identifies verb forms across all tenses and derived forms (II–VIII, X)
- Matches short surahs (from Juz 'Amma) to their central themes
- Applies Tajweed rules of Idgham, Iqlab, Ikhfa, and various types of Madd
- Reads Qur'anic verses with appropriate waqf and identifies verse-level meaning

EXAMPLE ITEM TYPE

اقرأ السورة التالية: "إِنَّا أَعْطَيْنَاكَ الْكَوْثَرَ". What is the primary theme of Surah Al-Kawthar?

- a) the story of Nuh
- b) charity to orphans
- c) the abundant gift granted to the Prophet ﷺ
- d) rules of fasting

B2 — Advanced (Mutaqaddim | مُتَقَدِّم)

STANDARD CEFR DESCRIPTOR

"Can understand the main ideas of complex text on both concrete and abstract topics, including technical discussions in his/her field of specialisation. Can produce clear, detailed text on a wide range of subjects and explain a viewpoint on a topical issue giving the advantages and disadvantages of various options."

RAQP EVIDENCE

- Reads and comprehends extended classical and modern texts including tafsir excerpts, hadith, and modern MSA prose
- Recognizes ~2,500 vocabulary items including specialized Islamic terminology
- Identifies full case system (nominative, accusative, genitive) in complex clauses
- Applies advanced Tajweed rules including tafkhim/tarqiq and Raa/Lam distinctions
- Reads longer Qur'anic passages and identifies theme, structure, and rhetorical devices
- Recognizes morphological patterns (masdar, ism al-fa'il, ism al-maf'ul) and traces to roots

EXAMPLE ITEM TYPE

اقرأ التالي: "إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَالْإِحْسَانِ وَإِيتَاءِ ذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ". Which best describes the rhetorical structure?

- a) simple negation
- b) parallel imperative construction
- c) conditional statement
- d) rhetorical question

Scoring and level determination

Every candidate takes the RAQP at their **chosen entry level**. From there:

- **A1 (Beginner) candidates** must achieve $\geq 60\%$ on A1 items. Below 60%, the certificate reads "Pre-A1 / In Progress" and a retake is scheduled.
- **A2 candidates** need $\geq 60\%$ overall AND $\geq 50\%$ on A2-specific vocabulary/grammar items.
- **B1 candidates** need $\geq 60\%$ overall AND $\geq 50\%$ on B1-specific items AND $\geq 65\%$ on A2 items.
- **B2 candidates** need $\geq 60\%$ overall AND $\geq 50\%$ on B2-specific items AND $\geq 65\%$ on B1 items.

Certificate uses the highest level for which the candidate meets all cutoffs. A candidate who signs up for B2 but only hits the A2 cutoff receives an A2 certificate — never a B2 certificate they didn't earn.

What a Roots CEFR certificate does and does not entitle

A Roots CEFR-A1 through CEFR-B2 certificate confirms that on a specific date, the candidate demonstrated the specified level of Arabic and Qur'anic Arabic proficiency on the RAQP exam.

It **does** provide a portable, verifiable statement that any teacher, evaluator, or admissions officer can trust as a placement signal.

It **does not** confer teaching qualification, ijazah in recitation, a formal higher-education diploma, or legal equivalence to state-issued language proficiency documents.

How this alignment was built

1. **Descriptor match** — the item's underlying language task was mapped to specific "can-do" verbs in the CEFR descriptor.
2. **Vocabulary check** — cross-checked against recommended lexical range in Arabic-language CEFR studies (Al-Batal 2018; Alosch & Clark 2013).
3. **Grammar check** — cross-checked against ACTFL Arabic CEFR grammar progression tables.
4. **Second reviewer** — every item reviewed by a second native-Arabic-speaking educator before entering the bank.
5. **Field piloting** — items piloted with students of known proficiency levels before final flag.

Items that failed any check were revised or removed. The current bank of 240 items is the surviving set.

Version, review, and challenge

- **Document version:** v1, published 2026-07-15
- **RAQP item bank version:** v1 (240 items)
- **Independent review:** Pending. Named reviewers will be added as they contribute.

To challenge a specific CEFR tagging: email dinabudu@gmail.com with the item ID and your reasoning. All challenges are reviewed.

References

- Council of Europe. (2020). *Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: Learning, teaching, assessment — Companion Volume*. Strasbourg: Council of Europe Publishing.
- Al-Batal, M. (Ed.). (2018). *Arabic as one language*. Georgetown University Press.

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- ACTFL. (2012). *Proficiency Guidelines*. Alexandria, VA: American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages.

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